

RING FORTS

The Vikings built fortified towns called ring forts. Ditches and earthen ramparts, or walls, topped with wooden logs made it hard for attackers to get inside. Each ring fort had four gates – placed north, south, east, and west. They were narrow, making them easier to defend. Mythical Asgard – with its wall built by giants – is similar to a ring fort.

Inside the ringed walls of the fort were houses, stables and workshops.



The Norse asked Freyr, god of fertility, to bless their marriages with happiness and good fortune. Freya, a popular goddess, was also called upon in matters of love.

RELIGIOUS BELIEFS

The early Norse people believed in many gods and goddesses, including the major deities from Norse myths, such as Odin, Thor, Freya, Freyr and Sif. People made figurines of them to worship. Later, the Norse were converted to Christianity.

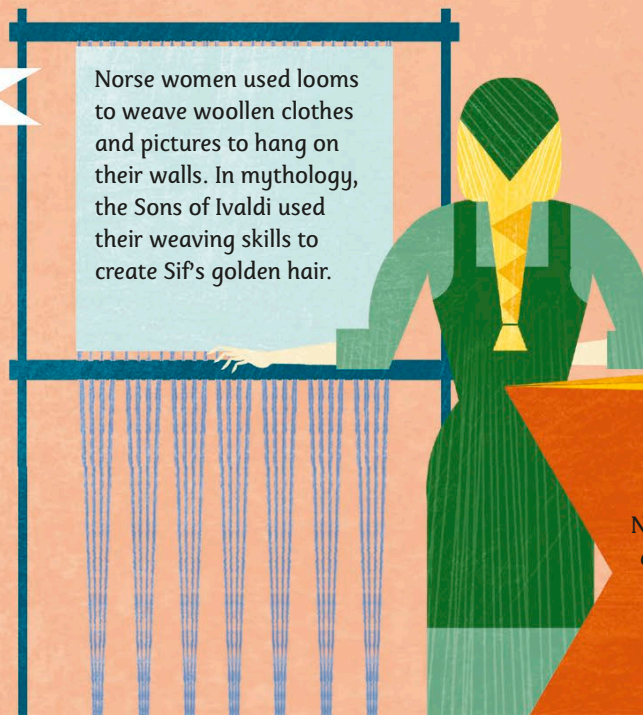


After a brave death, it was believed a Viking's soul was carried to Valhalla – a majestic hall for eating, drinking, fighting and celebrating.

CRAFTWORKERS

Like the dwarfs in their myths, the Norse were skilled craftworkers. Blacksmiths hammered red-hot iron to make knives, axe-heads, spear-tips, arrowheads, swords, and tools for farming and housework. Jewellers used gold, silver, bronze and pewter (a mixture of tin and lead) to make bracelets, necklaces (torques), brooches, and finger- and arm-rings.

Norse women used looms to weave woollen clothes and pictures to hang on their walls. In mythology, the Sons of Ivaldi used their weaving skills to create Sif's golden hair.



The Norse were expert blacksmiths. The dwarfs of Norse myth made treasures such as Thor's hammer, Mjölnir, and Odin's spear, Gungnir.